of welfare housing on an unprecedented scale—in a country where legal inheritance rights on parental property were only extended fully to all women in August 2020 by a Supreme Court judgement[26]—embodied revolutionary new possibilities and a major shift for rural women.

This chapter shows how these policies collectively led to the remaking of the women's vote in India and powered the BJP's political ascendance. The initiatives to create a new national constituency for the party on gender lines changed the conventional rules of Indian politics. They also raise vexing questions around women's empowerment, patriarchy, modernity and Hindu nationalism that deserve deeper examination.

Women Voted More for the BJP than Men Did in 2019, Especially in Hindi-speaking States

The 2019 Lok Sabha poll marked a watershed. Women voters in India had always lagged behind men since 1962, which is when the ECI started making available separate figures for men and women voters. That year, 62.1 per cent of men voters turned out to vote, compared to 46.7 per cent women. The gender gap in turnout was a huge 15.4 per cent, wrote Prannoy Roy and Dorab Sopariwala. By 2014, the year Modi won his first national election for the BJP, this gap had narrowed down to just 1.5 per cent (67 per cent men vs 65.5 per cent women).[27] In 2019, however, when Modi won his second mandate, the gender gap in turnout had not only disappeared, it was now slightly in favour of women. The women's turnout during Modi's second, and bigger, national triumph was 67.17 per cent (29,41,01,483 women voted out of 43,78,06,707 registered women voters) compared to 67 per cent for men (31,67,19,158 men voted out of 47,26,66,414 registered men voters).[28] For the first time, women overtook men in turnout.[29] This was also the first general election in which women voted more than men in favour of the BJP-led NDA.

The significance of the women's vote for the BJP must not be underestimated. Earlier, the party's support base amongst women